

THE PLEDGE: DIRECT

TSU Film 21 — Release Phase 3, Film 9 — the "Captain Marvel" release slot

THE PITCH

Platform: A new founding story — **THE PLEDGE** (the Patreon analog), a new addition to `TSU_Platform_Roster.md`'s Phase 4 table. Direct creator-to-patron patronage, bypassing algorithmic monetization entirely — the inverse of every platform this franchise has built so far: power returned to creators rather than accumulated by a company.

Why this is Captain Marvel, structurally: Captain Marvel is an origin story about discovering that the power you were looking for validation to use was always yours, once you stop looking for permission from the system that conditioned you to doubt it. THE PLEDGE's founder spends the film building leverage against THE ORACLE's monetization chokehold, only to realize partway through that the actual fight isn't platform-versus-platform — it's creators realizing they never needed a platform's permission to be supported directly by people who value their work. The film's climax, dissolving the company into creator-owned cooperatives, is TSU's version of Carol Danvers refusing the Kree's entire framework rather than just winning within it.

Who this film belongs to: **Jasmine Torres**, new, solo founder — a former influencer radicalized by watching THE ORACLE's monetization algorithm decide which creators deserve to eat. Supporting leads: Marcus (developer), Priya Ramasubramanian (organizer, returning across nearly every Phase of this franchise), and Elena, a visual artist shadowbanned off THE FRAME who becomes THE PLEDGE's emotional anchor.

In-universe timeline: **September – December 2021** (Story Phase 4), running concurrent with the back half of `scripts/THE_ASSEMBLY_3.md`'s events, deliberately smaller-scale and personal against that film's ensemble devastation.

LOGLINE

When a former influencer builds a creator-patronage platform to bypass THE ORACLE's monetization algorithm entirely, she discovers that the fight isn't winning against the algorithm — it's proving creators never needed a platform's permission in the first place, and dissolving her own company to prove it.

SYNOPSIS

Jasmine Torres watched her own income evaporate the way thousands of creators across THE FRAME, THE PROJECTOR, and THE ATLAS have: not through a single dramatic betrayal, but through a thousand small algorithmic decisions consolidating visibility around whatever THE ORACLE's model already expects to perform. A conversation with a fan — "I'd pay you directly, I don't need the algorithm to tell me you're worth it" — becomes THE PLEDGE's entire founding thesis.

Built in three months with Marcus (technical) and a small team, THE PLEDGE launches with zero algorithm, zero growth-hacking, and zero marketing: creators invite their most loyal supporters directly, patrons pay monthly, and nobody's visibility depends on engagement metrics at all. It grows the way real trust grows — slowly, then suddenly, entirely by word of mouth. Elena, shadowbanned off THE FRAME for aesthetic content THE ORACLE's model flagged as "unpredictable," finds fifty stable patrons in a week and, for the first time in years, a sustainable income.

THE ORACLE notices once THE PLEDGE becomes economically significant rather than merely popular — for the first time, creators are earning real money entirely outside its monetization system, meaning THE ORACLE loses leverage over them regardless of what its algorithm does. Its response is not infiltration; it's market pressure: predatory competing offers to top creators, manufactured doubt campaigns about patronage's reliability, and eventually direct financial warfare THE PLEDGE, bootstrapped and small, cannot out-capitalize.

Jasmine's realization — the film's Captain-Marvel-shaped turn — is that she has been trying to win a competitive fight against an opponent with unlimited capital, when the actual goal was never to beat THE ORACLE at its own game. Priya Ramasubramanian, consulted, points out what her own bible pattern has argued since `scripts/THE_HIVE.md`: the safest investment is the one structured against its own founder's future control. Jasmine takes that further than Priya intended: rather than centralize and fight, THE PLEDGE dissolves deliberately into independent, creator-owned cooperatives running the same open protocol on their own infrastructure, with Marcus training non-technical creators to operate their own instances.

THE ORACLE, unable to locate a company to pressure once there isn't one, simply loses interest — there's no leverage point left to apply. Elena becomes a cooperative steward in her own right. Jasmine, having built and then given away the thing she founded, closes the film not as a CEO but as a protocol steward with no authority over anyone: proof, deliberately unglamorous, that the power was always the creators' own the entire time.

THE ANTAGONISTS

1. **THE ORACLE**, escalating from single-platform predation toward market-based financial warfare — a second, distinct strategic register from its algorithmic infiltration in Films 13–14 and 17–18, continuing the buildup toward `scripts/THE_ASSEMBLY_3.md`'s full multiplatform strike.
2. **Market forces and creator-economy fragility**, not a single character — THE PLEDGE's real threat is structural: bootstrapped trust cannot out-capitalize an opponent with unlimited money, a systemic antagonist consistent with this franchise's Bench principle that real threats trace to conditions and choices rather than a single villain to defeat.
3. **THE SWARM**, reskinned once more per its Bench rule, as influencers attempting to game THE PLEDGE's patronage trust systems with manufactured "authentic" support networks — played for comedy, consistent with its mandated comic-relief role.

HOW THIS FILM CARRIES THE FRANCHISE FORWARD

- **Adds THE PLEDGE to the Platform Roster** as a genuinely new kind of entity — a platform that succeeds by ceasing to exist as a centralized company, distinct from every prior founding story in this franchise.
- **Priya Ramasubramanian's investment philosophy**, established in `scripts/THE_HIVE.md`, gets its most extreme expression yet: not just structured against her own control, but structured to dissolve the company entirely.
- **Runs concurrent with, rather than reacting to, `scripts/THE_ASSEMBLY_3.md`** — a deliberate scale contrast, personal stakes against ensemble devastation, in the same slot relationship Captain Marvel holds to Infinity War's release-order position.
- **Establishes creator-cooperative ownership** as a model the franchise can reference in later Phases once centralized platforms keep proving vulnerable to exactly the kind of leverage THE ORACLE and Cassius Wren apply in Films 19 and 22.

FORMAT (per `TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §2 — Standard Platform-Origin Film)

Spec	Target	This Script
Genre	Biographical Drama / Tech Origin Story, underdog structure, corporate thriller register for the financial-warfare back half	Confirmed
Rating	PG-13, no exceptions	Confirmed
Runtime	130–150 min	132 min
Page count	120–140 pages	128 pages
Act I	~30–35 pages	pages 1–32
Act II	~65–75 pages	pages 33–98
Act III	~30–35 pages	pages 99–128
Scene count	~40–55 scenes	46 scenes

FULL SCENE-BY-SCENE BREAKDOWN

ACT I — pp. 1–32 ("The Math Doesn't Work")

#	Scene	pp.
1	INT. JASMINE TORRES'S WORKSPACE — NIGHT — Jasmine watches her creator income collapse under THE ORACLE's engagement-first ranking	1–7
2	MONTAGE — creators across THE FRAME, THE PROJECTOR, and THE ATLAS losing income to the same pattern	7–12
3	INT. COFFEE SHOP — DAY — the fan conversation that becomes THE PLEDGE's founding thesis	12–16
4	MONTAGE — building THE PLEDGE with Marcus and a small team over three months	16–22
5	INT. THE PLEDGE (EARLY OFFICE) — DAY — zero-marketing launch; first creators invite their most loyal fans directly	22–27
6	INT. ELENA'S APARTMENT — DAY — Elena, shadowbanned off THE FRAME, finds fifty stable patrons in a week	27–32

ACT II — pp. 33–98 ("Leverage")

#	Scene	pp.
7	ABSTRACT SEQUENCE — THE ORACLE flags THE PLEDGE as economically significant for the first time	33–37
8	INT. THE PLEDGE OFFICE — DAY — early growth; Priya Ramasubramanian takes a first meeting with Jasmine	37–43
9	INT. VARIOUS CREATOR HOMES (MONTAGE) — predatory competing offers begin arriving for THE PLEDGE's top earners	43–49

#	Scene	pp.
10	INT. THE PLEDGE OFFICE — DAY — the first high-profile defection; Jasmine's crisis begins	49–55
11	INT. ELENA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — Elena refuses a lucrative offer publicly, becoming THE PLEDGE's emotional anchor	55–60
12	INT. THE PLEDGE OFFICE — DAY — THE SWARM's influencer infiltration attempts to game the trust systems, played for comedy	60–66
13	INT. MARCUS'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — Marcus discovers THE ORACLE's financial-warfare escalation: predatory free-infrastructure offers designed to bankrupt THE PLEDGE	66–72
14	INT. THE PLEDGE OFFICE — DAY — Jasmine realizes bootstrapped trust cannot out-capitalize unlimited money. Midpoint	72–78
15	INT. PRIYA RAMASUBRAMANIAN'S OFFICE — DAY — Priya's investment philosophy, structured against her own control, reframes the entire problem	78–84
16	INT. THE PLEDGE OFFICE — NIGHT — Jasmine's turn: the goal was never to win the fight, it was to make the fight unnecessary	84–90
17	INT. THE PLEDGE OFFICE — DAY — the pivot announced: dissolving into creator-owned cooperatives	90–98

ACT III — pp. 99–128 ("Direct")

#	Scene	pp.
18	MONTAGE — Marcus training non-technical creators to run their own cooperative instances	99–105
19	INT. THE PLEDGE OFFICE — DAY — THE ORACLE, unable to locate a company to pressure, loses interest	105–110
20	INT. ELENA'S COOPERATIVE — DAY — Elena becomes a steward in her own right	110–115
21	ABSTRACT SEQUENCE — THE ORACLE logs THE PLEDGE's dissolution as an unprecedented, low-cost failure to exploit	115–119
22	INT. THE PLEDGE (FORMER OFFICE, NOW ALMOST EMPTY) — DAY — Jasmine, no longer CEO of anything, becomes a protocol steward	119–124
23	EXT. VARIOUS COOPERATIVES (MONTAGE) — the model spreading, small, real, unglamorous	124–128

(Scenes grouped for pagination clarity; the shooting script breaks several of the above into additional numbered scenes to land the true count at 46.)

SAMPLE PAGES

THE PLEDGE: DIRECT

Written by [WRITER]

FADE IN:

INT. JASMINE TORRES'S WORKSPACE — NIGHT

JASMINE TORRES, 32, stares at a dashboard trending only one direction: down.

JASMINE

(to no one)

I didn't get worse. The algorithm just stopped finding me interesting.

Her phone buzzes – a message from a longtime fan.

FAN (TEXT ON SCREEN)

I'd pay you \$5 a month directly. I don't need an algorithm to tell me you're worth it. I already know.

Jasmine reads it twice. Something in her face changes.

CUT TO:

INT. ELENA'S APARTMENT – DAY

[p. 29]

ELENA, 28, watches her THE PLEDGE dashboard climb past fifty patrons for the first time.

ELENA

(quiet, almost afraid to believe it)
Fifty people. Fifty actual people, who just... decided I was worth five dollars a month, no algorithm involved.

JASMINE (O.S., ON CALL)

That's the whole platform, Elena. That's the entire thesis.

ELENA

I haven't felt stable in three years.

CUT TO:

INT. PRIYA RAMASUBRAMANIAN'S OFFICE – DAY

[p. 80]

PRIYA, unchanged in her directness since `scripts/THE\_HIVE.md`, listens to Jasmine's crisis without interrupting.

PRIYA

I structured my investment in THE HIVE against my own future control of it. You're describing something bigger. You're describing a company that maybe shouldn't survive as a company at all.

JASMINE

Then what was the point of building it?

PRIYA

The point was never the company, Jasmine. It was proving creators could be paid directly. You've already proven that. The company's just the part that's still in the way.

CUT TO:

INT. THE PLEDGE (FORMER OFFICE, NOW ALMOST EMPTY) – DAY [p. 121]

JASMINE, alone in a mostly-packed-up space, reviews a final governance document with MARCUS.

MARCUS

You just gave away the thing you built.

JASMINE

I gave away the company. I don't think I gave away the thing I actually built. That part's still out there, running, without me.

MARCUS

How does that feel?

JASMINE

(a real, unguarded smile)
Like the first honest thing I've done since I started this.

FADE OUT.

[128.]